

SEC merger-process extraction review

Independent assessment for Austin Li and Alex Gorbenko

26 September 2026 | 15 anonymous workbooks | Instruction v1.14

1. Main assessment

Use Mac-Gray A, Providence & Worcester B, and sTec B as the starting ledgers. Mac-Gray D and Providence & Worcester C are useful cross-checks; sTec C is particularly close to B. These are recommendations about individual workbooks, not extractors: A–E were randomized independently within each deal and must not be pooled across deals.

The strongest outputs reconstruct considerably more than a textbook auction. They preserve Mac-Gray's performance-contingent competing offer, Providence & Worcester's returning bidders and contingent-value rights, and sTec's preferred bidder withdrawing and returning at a lower price. The principal weaknesses are usually **interpretation and state assignment**, not invented quotations or failure to find the main bid prices.

Three problems matter most for structural estimation. First, some ledgers turn an NDA cohort observed over a period into a precisely dated set of deadline non-submitters. Second, they sometimes fill financing, diligence or regulatory states from a later passage or a weaker statement than the code requires. Third, economically important facts can be present in prose but absent from the structured fields that an estimator would consume. sTec's restriction on allowing rival bids is the clearest example.

None should be ingested directly as estimation-ready data. The leading workbooks are strong human-reviewable first passes, requiring targeted adjudication rather than wholesale re-extraction. The weaker workbooks remain useful evidence collections, but their participation and condition fields need more extensive repair. A genuine source quote and a useful Questions sheet do not make an unsupported point-coded state safe.

Scores by deal and anonymous letter

Deal	A	B	C	D	E	Preferred starting point
Mac-Gray	94	82	87	90	80	A; cross-check D
Providence & Worcester	86	94	90	78	84	B; cross-check C
sTec	89	94	92	84	82	B; C is a close alternative

Ordering: Mac-Gray A > D > C > B > E; Providence & Worcester B > C > A > E > D; sTec B ≈ C > A > D > E. Differences of two or three points are not robust enough to justify a strong preference by themselves. Larger gaps here generally correspond to a material difference in reconstructing participants, rounds or bid conditions.

What the scores mean

The scale is **0–100 research usefulness**, not a measured percentage of correct cells. I allocated 35 points to participant identity, entry, selection and exits; 25 to process boundaries, rounds, sequence and deadlines; 30 to bid economics, information and conditions; and 10 to evidence traceability and review usability. A material error receives more weight than several missing administrative details. I do not reward extra rows merely for being extra rows, or penalize a justified unknown merely for being unknown.

A score of 90 or more denotes a strong starting ledger with targeted repairs; 80–89 denotes a useful first pass with material corrections; 70–79 denotes substantial reconciliation before research use. These are judgmental bands, not calibrated error rates. The component allocations appear in Section 7 so that the weighting is transparent without imposing an elaborate checklist.

Evidence notation and scope

MG, **PW** and **ST** below refer respectively to the supplied Mac-Gray, Providence & Worcester and sTec filings. Page references are the filings' printed pages, including annex page labels, not browser or extraction-line numbers. A workbook reference such as **MG B #24** means event 24 on that workbook's **Deal ledger**, which is Excel row 25. All ledgers use the same columns: H–I price, M formality, N conditions, O diligence, P financing, Q regulatory, T count, V inferred, W note and X quotation. References to Questions or Rounds name those sheets explicitly. The source filenames and inspection scope are recorded in Section 8.

2. Mac-Gray: a richer offer is not necessarily a better cash bid

The reconstruction against which I assessed the workbooks

The earlier discussions concerned Mac-Gray acquiring CSC; they were not an earlier auction to sell Mac-Gray. Party A's \$17–19 cash indication on 21 June 2013 preceded the broad sale launch on 24 June. The outreach total was 50 parties, comprising 15 strategic and 35 financial parties. Twenty executed NDAs over the next two months: two strategic parties and 18 financial parties. Named financial Parties B and C leave a residual of 16 anonymous financial NDA signers, but that does not establish that all 16 were eligible for the 23 July deadline. [MG pp. 27–33.]

The first deadline produced CSC's \$18.50 cash offer on 23 July, B's \$17–18 and C's oral \$15–17 on 24 July, and C's written revision to \$16–16.50 on 25 July. A, B, C and CSC advanced, with A's NDA executed on 5 August. Financial bidders received broader initial data access than the strategic parties; the latter faced restrictions on customer-location information. The process also included separate synergy discussions with strategic bidders. These differences are economically relevant information treatments, not incidental meeting descriptions. [MG pp. 33–35.]

The next solicitation, issued on 27 August, requested proposals for 9 September. CSC offered \$19.50; B \$18.50; A offered \$18–19 on 10 September; C offered \$16–17 orally that day. The first explicitly final solicitation began on 11 September with a deadline of 18 September. CSC then offered \$20.75 cash. A reiterated its previous \$18–19 indication. B offered **\$19 cash plus performance options that B valued at \$2.50 per share**. Its \$21.50 headline was neither guaranteed cash nor an ordinary 10% upfront stock component. [MG pp. 35–37.]

C did not respond to the final solicitation and did not continue. A and B should not automatically be removed when the committee preferred CSC on 19 September; the executed exclusivity agreement on 24 September supplies a later closure event. CSC accepted \$21.25 on 21 September, with further commitment negotiations including a \$15 million regulatory reverse fee. Full access and confirmatory diligence followed exclusivity. October negotiations changed sponsor liability, including an unspecified cap in the 5 October draft and a \$50 million cap proposed on 8 October. These are material commitment events even without a newly quoted purchase price. Signing occurred on 14 October; announcement followed on 15 October. [MG pp. 36–41.]

The source does not identify exact individual exit dates for the 16 anonymous NDA signers. The four-party solicitation on 27 August, after the stated NDA accumulation period, supports an inferred closure by that stage. That is preferable to a fictional count of 16 eligible bidders all failing the July deadline. It is still a convention-based upper bound, not a source-reported mass elimination on 27 August. [MG pp. 32–35; v1.14 E3, E8 and E14.]

A – 94/100: the best research base

A handles the most consequential distinctions well. #33 closes the 16 residual signers by 27 August as an inferred target exclusion, explicitly rejecting an unsupported July non-submission count. #44 retains A's uncommitted-financing condition when A reiterates its previous indication. #45 places B's upfront cash at \$19 and its bidder-valued performance component separately at \$2.50, with zero upfront stock. These choices preserve the variables needed to study selection on terms rather than merely on headline price. [MG pp. 32–37; A #33, #44–45, especially H–P and W.]

A also preserves asymmetric data access, strategic synergy discussions, C's earlier exit, and the later exclusion of A and B under executed exclusivity. #61–62 separately capture the October sponsor-liability revisions while leaving purchase-price cells blank where the communication does not expressly restate price. This is preferable to manufacturing two additional observed \$21.25 bids. [MG pp. 34–35, 36–39; A #61–62.]

The remaining work is narrow. In #62, the 8 October oral cap proposal is Informal/Unclear with diligence Not stated, whereas the preceding commitment draft is Formal/Light. That may follow a strict communication-specific reading, but the actual negotiation remained within the definitive-document process. Questions Q7 makes the formality issue reviewable. I would standardize the treatment of these late commitment communications rather than treat this as a major factual failure. A is not a finished set of economically homogeneous bid observations, but it requires the least corrective reconstruction.

B – 82/100: good offer coverage, unsafe early attrition

B preserves the principal bids, the cash/options distinction, and the separate exits of C versus A/B. Its central problem is #24, which dates the anonymous cohort's non-submission closure by 23 July even though #21 records NDA execution over an interval extending into August. Its own note says the number eligible on 23 July is unknown. Leaving Count blank and discussing the problem in Q2 does not repair the dated event or the associated round transition. [MG pp. 32–35; B #21, #24; Rounds round 1; Questions Q2.]

Two condition assignments are too strong. #41 converts the committee's later statement that B would likely use affiliated equity and third-party debt into financing Contingent and conditions Heavy. The source of funds and a comparative financing risk are not themselves proof that financing was unarranged at the 18 September bid. B at least marks this inference and explains it in Q5. #55 and #57 carry \$21.25 and Committed financing into October liability revisions without a newly expressed price or financing commitment in those communications. [MG pp. 36–39; B #41, #55, #57; v1.14 E10 and E12.]

The contact row #11 also introduces a 47–48 residual by treating CSC and Pamplona as potentially separate party units, whereas the extraction convention treats the operating bidder and sponsor together. The workbook is readable and source-rich, but its early attrition and inferred condition states should not be used without correction.

C – 87/100: sound population closure, incomplete economic detail

C correctly postpones closure of the anonymous 16 until the complete 27 August solicitation in #33. It also preserves the principal prices, B's contingent option component and the distinction between financial and strategic data access. It is much safer than B or E on the initial participation history. [MG pp. 32–36; C #31–33 and final bid rows.]

Its clearest substantive weakness is #45: A's final response carries the prior price range but drops the financing state to Not stated. The filing says A reiterated its previous indication, not merely a standalone price. The prior proposal's uncommitted funding should therefore remain visible under the instruction's express-reference rule, or the narrower interpretation should at least be flagged. C also omits the separate strategic-only synergy discussions, although it retains the broader access asymmetry. This loses an informative distinction in what bidders could learn. [MG pp. 34–36; C #45, P46 and W46; v1.14 E10.]

C treats the 5 October commitment draft as Informal and subsequently creates an October 7 Bid reaffirmed event. These are reviewable consequences of the rule distinguishing priced proposals from commitment-document revisions, not grounds for claiming fabricated negotiation events. Its Heavy classification of CSC's September 9 offer, based on anticipated more in-depth diligence, is also less decisive than the population or financing issues. I give that interpretive boundary less weight. [MG pp. 34–35, 39; C #36, #58–59.]

D — 90/100: strong detail, but one stage too late on the residual

D is a strong alternative, preserving bidder identities, the non-cash option economics, information asymmetry, synergy discussions and material late commitment changes. It does not force anonymous NDA signers into the July deadline. However, #42 closes the 16 only by 11 September, describing this as the first complete advancing set after the NDA window. The 27 August four-party solicitation already provides an earlier supported closure bound. Carrying the residual further into the process weakens the reconstructed competition set and round summary. [MG pp. 32–36; D #42; Rounds round 2.]

Like C, D's #46 retains A's previous cash range but makes financing Not stated despite the reference to its previous indication. This can create an artificial improvement in A's apparent commitment between September 10 and September 18. #53 then classifies CSC's September 21–23 commitment revision Light while diligence is Not stated. That merits review rather than silently treating committed financing as sufficient for a light remaining-condition state. [MG pp. 35–38; D #46 and #53.]

These corrections are localized. D is particularly useful as a cross-check on the richer negotiation chronology, but A has the cleaner population bound and financing carry treatment.

E — 80/100: substantial inference is presented as observed structure

E preserves the main bid ladder and the \$19 cash/\$2.50 option split, but #23 records exactly 16 anonymous Did not submit exits by 23 July while admitting that their eligibility on that date is not established. This is a substantive participation error, not just an imprecise date. It can turn later or uncertain entrants into observed failures to bid. [MG pp. 32–35; E #23, T24 and W24; Questions Q2.]

E also makes more aggressive condition inferences than the better workbooks. #39 marks B's final financing Contingent and conditions Heavy from the later discussion of likely financing sources, without marking that row inferred. #37 uses the later confirmatory-diligence description to label CSC's September 18 conditions Light. The confirmatory phase described on page 38 follows exclusivity; its description does not establish the exact remaining work at every earlier proposal. [MG pp. 36–38; E #37 and #39.]

#53–54 populate October purchase price and funding through carry-forward inference. The price inference is disclosed, but it should not become an additional observed price communication. A smaller internal inconsistency is #34, which says A's range was unchanged although the recorded earlier range was \$17–19 and the new range is \$18–19. The numeric cells are right; the note is not. E is usable as a source-linked draft, but its current fields are too assertive for unattended research use.

3. Providence & Worcester: finalists, returning rivals and non-comparable terms

The reconstruction against which I assessed the workbooks

The initial outreach involved 29 parties, 11 strategic and 18 financial. The narrative reports 25 initial NDAs, comprising 11 strategic and 14 financial parties. Nine initial indications arrived from 19 May through 1 June, after a deadline initially set for 10 May and postponed to 19 May. Seven parties advanced. Party C entered later, signed an NDA and submitted a \$21 indication on 12 July before receiving data-site access. The filing's later overall NDA total is not entirely easy to reconcile with this new entrant; an extraction should retain the discrepancy rather than silently manufacture a uniquely identified cohort. [PW pp. 28–30, 33.]

The next solicitation requested LOIs and document comments for 20 July. The six late-July proposals were not equivalent objects. The summary below is the comparison basis, not a substitute extraction of every term. [PW pp. 29–30.]

Bidder	Reported offer	Important distinction
B	\$24; consideration mix unstated	Expedited diligence; merger and voting-agreement markups
G&W	\$20.02 cash + \$1.13 South Quay CVR	Three-week exclusive diligence; markups; \$21.15 package
D	\$21; mix unstated	Four-week diligence; markup
E	\$21.26; mix unstated	60-day exclusivity for diligence/documents; issues list, not a markup
C	\$19.30; mix unstated	30-day diligence
F	\$19.20; mix unstated	30-day diligence

The filing additionally warns that the LOIs used **different transaction-expense and change-in-control-payment assumptions that could affect the ultimate price**. This caveat should survive extraction. A comparison that treats all quoted prices as the same net consideration measure would be stronger than the source permits. [PW p. 30.]

G&W raised its package to \$22.15 on 26 July, comprising \$21.02 cash plus the same \$1.13 CVR. B and G&W became the selected negotiating parties. D and E later returned with revisions, but their return did not automatically admit them to the same final stage. E's subsequent return to \$21.26 was a price reversion, not an exit. F's willingness to finance E did not establish a joint bidder or a new independent entry. B's August 4 markup occurred while diligence continued, not after all conditions disappeared. [PW pp. 30–31.]

G&W was told its proposal was not competitive but invited to continue diligence; it should not be exited and then re-entered. Its August 12 \$25 cash proposal eliminated the CVR and had a bidder-imposed expiry on August 13, not a new target-set bidding deadline. The board's later assessment that B and G&W did not differ materially in STB timing or likelihood was a comparative assessment, not a finding of zero regulatory risk and not necessarily a condition communicated with the morning bid. B was told that a higher offer existed; the filing does not expressly say B was told the exact \$25 amount. Signing was August 12 and announcement August 15. [PW pp. 31–32.]

A – 86/100: good late-stage history, weaker early cohort and price-comparison detail

A preserves G&W's cash/CVR decomposition, the distinction between E's reversion and withdrawal, F's financing role, B's formal reaffirmation and continuing diligence, and G&W's continued participation. Those are substantial strengths for this research. [PW pp. 29–32; A late-July and August bid/exit rows.]

The largest weakness is **#17**: at least 16 initial NDA signers are closed as Did not submit by June 1, while the note acknowledges unknown solicitation eligibility and uncertain overlap between NDA signers and the nine IOI bidders. The source supports residual uncertainty and a complete advancement set; it does not support that clean behavioral classification for every residual signer. A also omits the common caveat about different LOI expense and change-in-control assumptions, losing an important qualification to cross-bid price comparisons. [PW pp. 28–30; A #17; v1.14 E3 and E14.]

There are avoidable audit defects. **#33** says G&W's July 26 revision revises #25, but the relevant earlier G&W bid is #26. **#47** points to #39 rather than D's relevant revised bid at #43. **#54** says BMO conveyed the competing \$25 offer to B; the source says a higher proposal had been received. The exact number revealed to a rival matters for information and response modeling. Some August 2 placements also impose greater day-level precision on D's exit sequence than the narrative supplies. These issues justify a lower score than C despite a largely sound late-stage narrative.

B – 94/100: strongest treatment of uncertainty and information timing

B best separates the identified facts from the unresolved population. **#18** keeps the residual closure count blank and gives a 16–24 range conditional on cohort overlap, rather than presenting 25 minus 9 as a uniquely identified population. It uses the complete advancement set for an inferred closure instead of declaring a dated failure to submit. The wide bound is not especially convenient, but it is preferable to an unsupported point estimate; its interpretation must remain conditional on the cohort assumptions. [PW pp. 28–29, 33; B #18; Questions Q4.]

The offer rows preserve the expense/change-in-control caveat, upfront cash versus CVR, and the difference between E's issues list and other bidders' markups. **#52** correctly treats B's August 4 markup as a formal reaffirmation while diligence is still Incomplete. **#58** records the board's later comparative STB assessment separately instead of projecting it backward into G&W's morning bid. It also avoids claiming that B learned the exact competing price. [PW pp. 29–32; B #29–34, #52 and #58.]

B recovers G&W's April 3 NDA date from the annex and keeps useful date windows for selection and D's withdrawal. It is not able to resolve the filing's NDA-population ambiguity, nor should it be. The main remaining task is to adjudicate that population definition and retain interval-valued states downstream. The score rewards transparent uncertainty, not a claim that the broad numerical bound is the uniquely correct economic population.

C – 90/100: strong late-stage detail, too exact on the initial residual

C is close to B in its useful treatment of prices, conditions, document engagement and regulatory comparison. It retains the common LOI expense caveat, the bidder-specific terms, B's later markup and the non-price comparison of transaction protections. It is a strong cross-check for the late-stage negotiation. [PW pp. 29–32; C late-July bid rows, #61 and #64.]

The difference is **#18**, which places 16 in Count using 25 initial NDA entries minus nine IOI submitters. Its note and Q4 disclose an assumed population reading, so the inference is not hidden. Nevertheless, a point-coded count and the resulting exact-looking sequence in Rounds are stronger than the established overlap of the two source populations. The safer representation is conditional arithmetic or a bound with a blank point count. [PW pp. 28–29, 33; C #18, T19; Questions Q4; Rounds.]

C also places D's withdrawal on August 2 even though the filing gives a sequence following the August 1 revision rather than an unambiguous date for that withdrawal. The missing April 21 introductory meeting with

B is a smaller completeness issue. These are repairable defects; they do not undermine the main bid reconstruction. C's lower score than B is chiefly about false precision, not missing headline offers.

D – 78/100: overlapping participants and over-strong conditions

D retains much of the late competition correctly, including G&W's cash/CVR split, the return of D and E, E's price reversion and F's distinct financing role. Its weak point is the participant accounting. #9 records all 11 strategic NDA signers and #11 and #16 separately add G&W and B while acknowledging that they may already be among those 11. Without a residual-cohort adjustment or a non-additive marker, these rows cannot safely be summed as unique entrants. #20 compounds this by declaring at least 25 eligible signers and a May 19 non-submission closure, although their eligibility is not established. [PW pp. 28–29, 33; D #9, #11, #16 and #20; Questions Q3.]

Several condition fields also overstate the evidence. The initial indications and C's July indication are classified as diligence Not begun because data-room access came later, despite prior confidential materials and interaction. #30 and #49 treat E's 60-day exclusivity for diligence and documentation as an H2 diligence-duration condition. The instruction expressly distinguishes an exclusivity period from a stated diligence period. [PW pp. 28–30; D #18, #26, #30 and #49; v1.14 E12.]

The Questions sheet makes these choices visible, but often recommends retaining them. This is a research-state problem, not merely a presentation problem. D needs substantial population reconciliation and conditionality repair before use.

E – 84/100: useful offer detail, avoidable state and timing overreach

E preserves the major bid economics, keeps E's original-price reversion distinct from exit, does not turn F into a joint bidder, and correctly retains G&W during the final competition. It also carries the LOI expense caveat in multiple bid notes. [PW pp. 29–32; E late-July and August bid rows.]

Like A, #18 classifies a residual of at least 16 as Did not submit even though population overlap and deadline eligibility are unresolved. #24 labels C's July 12 diligence Not begun solely because data-site access followed the offer; the filing says C already had an NDA and confidential memorandum. Absence of data-room access is not absence of diligence. [PW pp. 28–29; E #18, #24; v1.14 E3, E12 and E14.]

#56 assigns regulatory Concern to G&W's morning bid using the board's later STB assessment, despite also recording that assessment separately. E fails to recover the exact G&W NDA date from Annex A-48, leaving a fact unknown that the supplied file can resolve. Some deadline and exit-date assignments also need tightening. These do not erase the usefulness of its bid chronology, but B or C offers a safer base and a lower review burden.

4. sTec: withdrawal, lower re-entry and restrictions on renewed competition

The reconstruction against which I assessed the workbooks

The early Company A meeting was cancelled after an NDA draft; the filing does not establish an executed NDA or live whole-company entry. Company B's early contact similarly did not become an NDA-backed or bidding entry. An interested asset buyer is not automatically a whole-company competitor. These distinctions prevent inflation of the auction's starting population. The early cancellation date is not exact enough to mechanically establish a clean three-month gap before the later approach. [ST pp. 23–26.]

The April process had six named NDA relationships: E, D, F, G, WDC and H. WDC's April 17 addendum reused an underlying NDA dated January 29, 2009. E and F were reported as interested only in assets later in April. Under v1.14, that later scope information must not be used to backcast them as partial-only at NDA entry; their scope change should be recorded. This is a convention for uncertain scope, not proof that they positively intended a whole-company bid from the start. [ST pp. 26–28; Annex A-3; v1.14 E1 and E3.]

D's April 23 oral indication was **strictly greater than \$5.60**, with additional diligence requests before a written indication. The May 3 solicitation covered WDC, D and G, not H. WDC submitted \$6.60–7.10 cash; D's \$5.75 written offer arrived on May 10 after asking for more time. Acceptance of a late offer is evidence about enforcement even without an expressly announced extension. H's May 15 \$5–5.75 proposal was not a late response to a deadline it had not been given. [ST pp. 28–29.]

The May 16 final-round letters went to WDC and D, requesting responses by May 28. H was not admitted to that stage but was invited to improve its indication. WDC offered \$9.15 on May 28 with a merger markup and ancillary agreements. D missed deadlines but was allowed to continue; WDC withdrew on May 31, D continued into June and withdrew on June 5, and WDC returned on June 10 with \$6.60–7.10, expressly on its earlier transaction terms. The final price became \$6.85 on June 14. D's continued discussions and WDC's re-entry need not manufacture a third auction round. [ST pp. 29–32.]

Two later developments are especially important. **Cost-Reduction Projections were supplied to WDC and its adviser on June 19, after the price had been agreed**, rather than being the same information given to all earlier bidders. Separately, WDC resisted waiving the “don't ask, don't waive” restrictions binding E, F and H and indicated it might not proceed if the target waived them. That was a new material condition affecting the possibility of renewed competition. It belongs in structured commitment/condition data, not only in a prose note. [ST pp. 33–34, 45–46.]

A – 89/100: sound participant history, a key condition remains prose-only

A correctly keeps E and F in the entry history before their scope changes, preserves H as a reserve rather than an admitted finalist, and avoids exiting D merely because it missed a deadline. It has two rounds and correctly captures WDC's withdrawal and lower return on expressly referenced earlier terms. Its bid rows preserve D's strict lower threshold, the cash ranges and WDC's document engagement. [ST pp. 26–32; A #22, #28, #34, #36, #43, #55 and #57.]

The principal repair is **#63**. It records WDC's restriction on waiving rival standstills as an Other material event, leaving the structured bid-conditions fields empty. Under E10 and the H3 test, this is a material change in willingness to proceed and should be represented as a commitment-revision Bid with the condition captured. The information is not absent from the workbook; it is absent from the typed observations an estimator would use. Its exact June 20 date is also firmer than the filing's negotiation-window description warrants. [ST pp. 33–34; A #63; v1.14 E10 and E12.]

A does well on continuing diligence and the late projection/clean-team information. It does not recover the underlying WDC NDA's January 2009 date, which is available in Annex A-3. Overall it is a strong chronology, but B and C better convert the crucial late competition restriction into research-ready event structure.

B – 94/100: the best combination of detail and typed economic events

B gives the fullest useful reconstruction without inventing a new round when WDC returns. It preserves the six NDA relationships, E/F scope changes, H's reserve status, D's accepted late proposal and continued participation, and WDC's actual withdrawal. It recovers the January 2009 WDC NDA and identifies the later reuse. #56 retains the May 28 merger markup and specific ancillary agreements rather than treating \$9.15 as an unconditional cash bid. [ST pp. 26–32; Annex A-3; B #30, #37, #43, #48, #56, #72 and #74.]

Its most important advantage is #82, a June 20–23 commitment-revision Bid classified Formal/Heavy under H3 for WDC's standstill-waiver restriction, with price left blank because that communication does not restate it. #80 also preserves the later Cost-Reduction Projection disclosure. Together these capture two separate mechanisms: asymmetric information after price agreement and a bidder condition limiting renewed rivalry. [ST pp. 33–34, 45–46; B #80 and #82.]

B is conservative on dated diligence states at several bids, using Not stated rather than carrying a later status backward; it correctly records D's April 23 diligence as Incomplete. I do not treat every later Not stated as an error. Before estimation, I would review whether contemporaneous or explicitly dated ongoing work supports tighter states, while retaining the distinction between access, work remaining and a contractual diligence condition. The remaining gap is targeted standardization, not missing core competition history. Its greater row count is not the reason it wins.

C – 92/100: almost as useful, with a few unsupported cohort details

C shares B's most important advantages: two rounds; six NDA relationships; E/F scope-change exits; H in reserve; D not artificially exited at a missed deadline; and WDC's withdrawal, reduced return and formal earlier-term reference. #70 captures the late standstill-waiver restriction as a Heavy commitment-revision Bid with no invented new price. The June 19 forecast disclosure is also present. [ST pp. 26–34, 45–46; C #49, #61, #63, #68 and #70.]

C nevertheless makes a specific unsupported population assignment in #16: its nine uninterested outreach parties expressly include G. The filing identifies A and the financial sponsor in that aggregate, but G's membership in the nine is not established merely by its later withdrawal. Q4 itself acknowledges uncertainty in some cohort overlaps. This does not destroy the named bidder history, but it would contaminate a type- or stage-specific outreach conversion count. [ST pp. 26–28; C #16; Questions Q4.]

Some date bounds are unnecessarily loose: #46 allows H's feedback through May 26 although H's May 23 response gives a tighter upper bound, and #35 uses final-stage selection as a loose bound on E's earlier asset-scope exit. These are smaller than a false third round or omitted commitment condition. C is genuinely close to B; an analyst who values a slightly more compact ledger could reasonably choose it after the few stated repairs.

D – 84/100: a plausible story becomes an unsupported extra round

D preserves the key bid prices, NDA relationships, scope changes, H's reserve position and WDC's exit/re-entry. Its continuing-diligence descriptions and later information events are useful. The main disagreement is #51, which opens round 3 on May 31 because WDC had been selected and then withdrew, and D was invited to continue. The note calls this a reopening, but D had not been excluded; it had missed the latest deadline and was still in contact. The source does not establish an intervening suspension followed by a genuinely new common solicitation. [ST pp. 30–32; D #51; Rounds round 3; Questions Q3.]

The workbook flags a two-round alternative, which is good review practice. Nevertheless, the current round assignments would make WDC's reduced return and D's continuing activity look like observations from a new stage. The later best-and-final request to WDC does not retrospectively establish a May 31 third-round opening. Under v1.14 E6, two rounds is the better default here; the three-round segmentation should remain a sensitivity case rather than the accepted point coding.

Like A, #64 keeps the standstill-waiver restriction as Other material event instead of a material Bid/Heavy condition. [ST pp. 33–34.] Those two differences explain most of the gap: the source facts are largely found, but the round and commitment classifications would change the estimation sample.

E — 82/100: later scope is backcast into the entry population

E correctly preserves two rounds, H's reserve status, D's continued discussions and WDC's lower formal return. The main cash prices and the late projection disclosure are present. Its most serious issue is #15 and #17, where E and F's NDA rows recommend treating them as partial-only and exclude them from the live whole-company count because they later expressed asset-only interest. #24 and #26 consequently become Other material events rather than scope-change withdrawals. [ST pp. 26–28; E #15, #17, #24 and #26; Questions Q4.]

The initial scope is genuinely uncertain. The error is not failing to prove whole-company intent; it is choosing a backward-looking point classification contrary to the convention the extractor was given. The resulting four-entry whole-company population is not comparable to the six-entry convention used by the other four workbooks. This directly affects entry and selection estimates. An alternate scope scenario is useful, but it must not silently replace the declared main convention. [v1.14 E1 and E3; E Rounds.]

#67 also leaves WDC's late standstill condition outside the structured bid/condition fields and fixes it to June 20. #22 makes D's diligence Not stated despite the affirmative additional-work description, and the May 28 ancillary conditions are much less informative than in B. The underlying 2009 WDC NDA date is also not recovered. E remains a reviewable draft, but B/C require appreciably less reconstruction of the economically relevant state history.

5. Where the instructions create or amplify the problem

The tested convention must be distinguished from the economic estimand

I judged whether a workbook followed v1.14, while separately judging whether the resulting representation serves the research. I did not silently replace it with an older voice-note interpretation. The following differences affect comparisons even when the source text is read correctly.

“Formal” is a document/process classification, not readiness to close. Earlier collection guidance uses shortcuts such as treating ranges as informal; the current rule permits a range to be formal when it expressly retains definitive-document terms. sTec's June 10 \$6.60–7.10 return is the natural example. Conversely, PW's July 26 price-only revision can be Informal under the communication-specific rule despite occurring after a formal July 21 proposal. An estimator must not interpret such codes as a bidder losing all earlier knowledge or commitment. Preserve the formal route, document engagement, conditions and stage separately. [Collection Instructions p. 7; v1.14 E10–E12; PW pp. 29–30; ST p. 32.]

Material commitment changes are not necessarily new price observations. The current instruction correctly asks for bidder liability or other commitment revisions as Bid events. It also restricts price carry-forward. This produces perfectly legitimate Bid rows with blank prices. Counting every Bid row as an independent new valuation observation would overcount Mac-Gray's October liability negotiations and sTec's standstill restriction. The instruction would benefit from one small explicit distinction between a new/revised price and a non-price commitment revision, rather than requiring downstream users to infer it from blanks and prose. [v1.14 E10–E11; MG p. 39; ST pp. 33–34.]

Communication-specific state rules are difficult to combine with information accumulated over time. The instruction appropriately prohibits projecting signing certainty backward. But “Not stated at this communication” and “not known to the researcher at this date” are not the same. The first may be appropriate in a bid row while a separately supported diligence-history state is Incomplete. This explains some defensible A/D versus B/C differences in sTec. A minimal improvement is to state whether each field describes the current communication, the known state at that time, or an explicit bid condition. It should not invite

automatic carry-forward of financing or automatic inference that further diligence is a contractual condition. [v1.14 E10 and E12; ST pp. 28–33.]

Inferred closure is useful, but it is not an observed rejection hazard

The current instruction supplies a first-applicable closure convention to avoid immortal anonymous bidders. That is useful for a review ledger, but the resulting “Dropped by target, by date” observation is often an upper bound inferred from a complete advancing set. It is not necessarily a contemporaneously reported rejection by the target. The inferred marker, the type of supporting evidence, and the date interval must survive into the research data. Mac-Gray A/C are better than B/E here, but even their preferred closure is convention-based. [v1.14 E3, E8 and E14; MG pp. 32–35.]

For PW, different totals may describe different populations. A range such as B's 16–24 is a transparent conditional accounting statement, not a directly observed distribution of individual exits. The filing does not identify each member. No instruction can turn missing identities into individual transition observations. The minimal repair is a bounded or conditional cohort record that cannot be summed with overlapping named rows, rather than more elaborate invented bidder identities. [PW pp. 28–29, 33; PW B #18; PW D #9–16.]

Partial-only treatment changes the research population

The older collection instructions prioritize whole-company bidding and omit partial-only bids. v1.14 instead preserves material partial-acquisition context and forbids using a later scope change to rewrite earlier involvement. sTec E follows a plausible economic alternative but not the tested convention. Applying that alternative consistently would require revisiting entry counts across all deals, not rewarding one workbook for silently choosing it. Retain the current main coding and an explicit alternate scope interpretation where the filing never establishes initial intent. [Collection Instructions p. 7; v1.14 E1 and E3; ST pp. 26–28.]

The voice notes contain case interpretations that are not controlling facts

The earlier sTec notes favor two processes on the basis of an approximately three-month gap. In the filing, the relevant early cancellation is undated within a November interval; the next approach is February 13. That supports a question about segmentation, not a precisely verified three-month interruption. Similarly, the older notes' “soft, not extended” description of the May 3 deadline differs from v1.14's explicit Extended (late bid accepted) convention. The underlying observation to preserve is D's late accepted submission, not a claim that the target formally announced an extension. [Voice notes §VIII; ST pp. 23–25, 28–29; v1.14 E5 and E9.]

The old sTec description of a May 16 informal second round conflicts with the filing's final-round process letters and v1.14's finality rule. Older Mac-Gray comments can group eliminated parties at September 24, but C's earlier non-response should be distinguished from A/B closure at executed exclusivity. Earlier PW comments about B's August 4 proposal do not justify unconditional coding while diligence continued. In each case, the source plus the current declared convention should determine the main ledger; the older interpretation should remain a documented alternative, not hidden ground truth. [Voice notes §§I, II and VIII; MG pp. 36–38; PW p. 31; ST pp. 29–30.]

Finally, the voice notes' interest in stock-price movements is a sensible research motivation, not a requirement that these extractors download an external daily price series. I have not deducted points for missing external prices. Those data would be a separate research input and must not be replaced by an inferred explanation for WDC's lower bid.

6. Research-use decision and the smallest useful repair pass

Keep the best ledger from each deal, but repair states against the filing rather than voting across workbooks. Shared output agreement is not independent corroboration: the same convention can create the same mistake in several files. Conversely, a minority coding can be better, as with the structured late standstill condition in sTec B/C.

For **Mac-Gray A**, retain the anonymous cohort's bounded closure, the three stages and the cash/performance-option decomposition. Review October commitment-event formality and distinguish those rows from new price observations. Cross-check D for detailed negotiation coverage. Do not introduce the July 23 residual non-submission assumption from B/E. [MG A #33, #45 and #61–62.]

For **PW B**, adjudicate the initial-versus-overall NDA population and retain non-additive/interval accounting where it cannot be resolved. Keep late-entrant C, reserve and returning-rival status distinct from admission to the final stage. Preserve the LOI expense-assumption caveat, the cash/CVR split, and the limited information disclosed to B. Do not turn regulatory comparability or physical diligence completion into universal readiness to close. [PW B #18, #29–34, #52 and #58; PW pp. 28–32.]

For **sTec B**, retain two rounds, the scope-change history, H's reserve position, WDC's actual withdrawal and the lower return on earlier terms. Keep the June 19 information disclosure and June 20–23 standstill condition as separate mechanisms. Review the few diligence states with temporally explicit source evidence, not an automatic fill-forward. Use C to check omissions but do not import its unsupported G/cohort assignment. [ST B #30, #56, #72, #74, #80 and #82; ST C #16.]

Before estimation, require agreement on five high-impact outputs: the admissible participant set over each interval; the round/process map; actual price observations versus commitment-only revisions; the information and conditions available at each communication; and observed versus inferred exit reasons/times. A Questions-sheet resolution should update those fields or the downstream admissible set, not merely add another note next to a contradictory point code.

There is no need to restore a large mechanical architecture to accomplish this. The existing source-linked ledger plus a short, explicit adjudication record can work. The essential discipline is semantic: **do not allow an unresolved note to coexist with a single apparently resolved number or state that later code will treat as observed.**

7. Score components and sensitivity of the rankings

Workbook	Participants / 35	Process / 25	Economics & information / 30	Auditability / 10	Total / 100
MG A	34	24	27	9	94
MG B	26	23	24	9	82
MG C	33	22	23	9	87
MG D	31	24	26	9	90
MG E	25	23	24	8	80
PW A	28	23	27	8	86
PW B	32	24	29	9	94
PW C	30	23	28	9	90
PW D	23	22	25	8	78
PW E	27	23	26	8	84
ST A	34	24	22	9	89

Workbook	Participants / 35	Process / 25	Economics & information / 30	Auditability / 10	Total / 100
ST B	34	24	27	9	94
ST C	33	24	26	9	92
ST D	33	18	24	9	84
ST E	27	24	23	8	82

The allocations are expert judgments about research consequences, not a count of equally weighted mistakes. An issue that touches several concepts is not automatically deducted in every component. Evidence coverage and correctness contribute to the economics/information score even when the present instruction leaves a classification gray area. The tables are exact lookup aids; a score chart would imply more quantitative precision than these judgments warrant.

The leading choices do not depend on awarding points for more rows or superficial formatting. Mac-Gray B/E remain weaker when the debatable late-stage formality classifications are ignored, because their early non-submission closures are still unsupported. PW D remains weaker because of overlapping entry rows and deadline eligibility, independently of the exact regulatory coding. sTec B/C remain stronger for a structured-conditions use case because they type the late competition restriction as a commitment event. An analyst reading only narrative chronology would narrow the gap to A/D; an estimator using round counts would care more about D's third round. Thus the rankings are purpose-dependent in an explicit way, not universal measures of writing quality.

8. Inspection record, preservation and limitations

Materials inspected

All 15 workbooks opened successfully, with all four sheets readable: **Deal ledger, Rounds, Questions, Deal facts**. I inspected their contents, not just the source-quotation columns or a prior evaluation. The event counts were:

Deal	A	B	C	D	E	Total
Mac-Gray	72	64	64	74	64	338
Providence & Worcester	60	66	68	66	63	323
sTec	66	86	74	67	70	363
Total						1,024

I read the complete merger-background narratives and checked relevant other parts of the actual supplied filings, including offer/financing provisions, annex NDA definitions, transaction rationales and the sTec projection disclosures. I read the complete v1.14 instruction, the nine-page collection-instructions PDF and the voice-note document, including its embedded context images. The voice notes' older case discussions were used to understand the research and identify convention conflicts, not as scores for these anonymous files.

Source identities are [filings/mac-gray_2013-12-04_DEFM14A.htm](#),
[filings/providence-worcester_2016-09-20_DEFM14A.htm](#), [filings/stec_2013-08-08_DEFM14A.htm](#),

instruction_v1.14.md, research_context/CollectionInstructions_Alex_2026.pdf, and research_context/alex_voice_notes_2026-08.docx. Workbook references identify extractions/[deal]/[letter].xlsx. README and MANIFEST were also checked.

What the mechanical checks establish—and do not establish

All **1,024 ledger quotation anchors** were source-locatable after typographic/whitespace normalization and inspection of one initially unmatched quotation. Each was within the instruction's 30-word quotation limit. This is evidence against wholesale fabricated anchoring. It does **not** establish that every quote supports all fields in its row, that every printed page label is independently error-free, or that all material events have been extracted. The substantive defects above often occur beside genuine, accurately copied text.

The files' four-sheet structure was intact and usable. This was a content and structural-usability review, not an exhaustive visual inspection of every possible Excel viewport or a certification of all hyperlinks and workbook application behavior. The workbooks were not modified. SHA-256 checks against the supplied manifest verified that all 22 manifest-listed inputs remained byte-identical. No model identity, execution log or withheld evaluation was sought or used.

Limits on conclusions

No supplied file was unreadable. The ZIP's inner documents were not available through indexed file search, so the mounted archive and its extracted original bytes were read directly. That retrieval limitation did not prevent the assessment.

This is one independent adjudication of three deliberately supplied cases, not a blinded multi-rater experiment or an estimate of performance on unseen deals. The numerical grades should not be interpreted as statistical confidence intervals or model-wide accuracy. The filings themselves can leave populations, timing, intent and bidder-specific conditions unidentified. I have distinguished those source limits from extractor errors and from ambiguities introduced by the instruction. The recommended repair pass cannot create missing facts; it should make those limits usable rather than conceal them.